The Federal Association of German Industries (Bundesverband der Deutschen Industrie)

The Federal Association of German Industries (BDI) is an umbrella organization of the sectoral association of industries with 40 member associations which sum up to 100,000 companies employing 8 million people nationwide.

BDI is mandated to *strengthen Germany as an industrial nation*. BDI represents industries in Berlin, with the Bundestag and with the EU. The influence is in **shaping framework conditions** (laws and regulations) in Germany as well as in the European Union. The process of channeling BDI´s position to the government ("lobbying") is transparent (shared on website, verbally, and in written form).

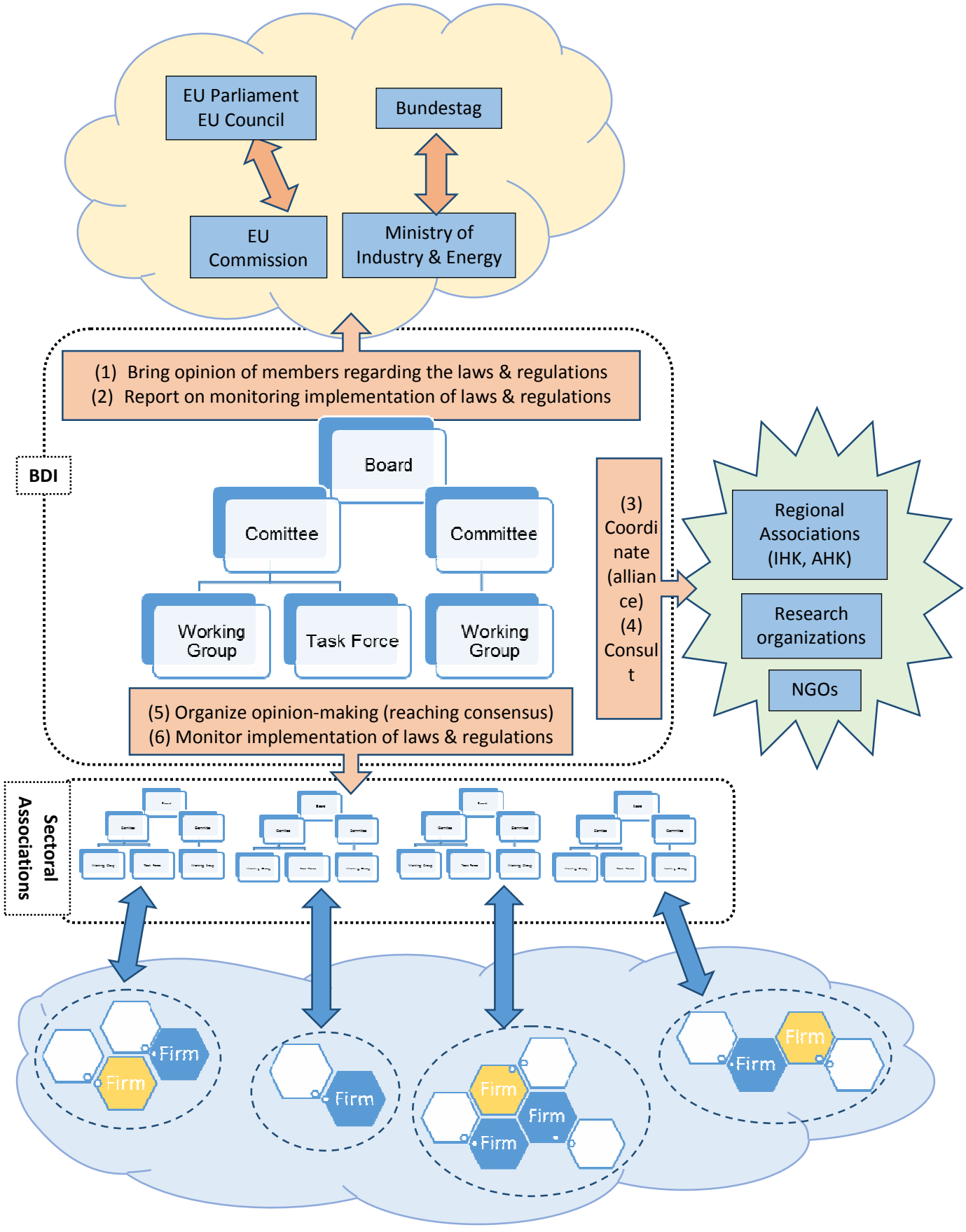
BDI *main function* is to coordinate with the member associations in order to have a "position" that is equally mandated by membership. Such position is consensus-based, therefore, the risk is not to have a position in cases where a consensus cannot be reached (within constraints of time and resources).

Member associations also have their processes to consolidate their position

The characteristics of BDI role:

- BDI- as the "mediator"- channels information in both directions: 1) brings views of the political level to the members (and their member firms), and 2) consolidates a shared opinion reflecting members´ interests.
- BDI is in the drivers´ seat of finding common ground, but sector-specific issues do not fall into the mandate (sector associations´ role).
- It was evident that BDI mastered the skills needed for consulting with the members on questions that would affect their sectors (framework conditions), and devised effective processes within the organization to push the negotiation of a common position (output shared with the public and the decision makers).
- The knowledge source in the system is the member associations or the "technical experts" existing in their member firms. In addition, through joint communication and exchange with the peers (experts in other associations on the regional/national level, business associations in other countries, and within the EU structures, Research organizations), additional options for a compromise can be offered on the negotiation table.
- Although legislation is taking place at higher level (German Parliament, EU Parliament), BDI recognizes the need to communicate with NGOs (to have the same direction on an issue) and public (to avoid making them feel out of control of decisions). Nevertheless, for BDI to continue to be trusted and not lose sense of the bigger thing, political decisions are supported, not questioned.

The following diagram shows BDI "functions" in relation to different organizations (representing a group or designated by state):


EU Parliament
EU Council
Bundestag
EU
Commission
Ministry of
Industry & Energy
(1) Bring opinion of members regarding the laws & regulations
(2) Report on monitoring implementation of laws & regulations
BDI
Board
Comittee
Committee
Working
Group
Task Force
Working
Group
(3)
Coordi
nate
(allian
ce)
(4)
Consul
t
Regional
Associations
(IHK, AHK)
Research
organizations
NGOs
(5) Organize opinion-making (reaching consensus)
(6) Monitor implementation of laws & regulations
Sectoral
Associations
Firm
Firm
Firm
Firm
Firm
Firm
Firm